

Eternal Rewards - Earned Today!

Jonathan Modene • Giving Back to Christ Jesus.

1 Corinthians 3:8 • Maumee Valley Bible Baptist

I. JUDGMENT OF ALL THINGS

We have looked at the word judgment that has been entrusted to Jesus Christ. He has been entrusted to judgment, all things, we have learned in the Bible. You say, "I want to do that myself, it's His job". Satan the adversary says, "*I'd like to control that.*" Sorry, God, the Father has entrusted the judgment **all things** to His only begotten son, the Lord Jesus Christ. You say, "*When will that happen*"? That will happen in the kingdom that is to become and beyond that kingdom, veiled from our sight. We have no idea how important this work is going to be. It is going to be a major preoccupation in the Kingdom of God.

II. CROSS WORK OF JESUS CHRIST

We look at the cross work of Jesus Christ, the cross work, how it was finished, but not all His work is over. He is not asleep right now. He is building some things, preparing some things, interceding for some people, preparing to come back.

When will he come back? He does not know. How foolish it is when a man says, "*I know the day.*" That is just foolish. You do not know and I do not know, Jesus Christ himself does not know. His cross work is finished. He will never be offered on the cross again.

The Roman Catholic Church, The Lutheran Church, churches that say we believe in the transubstantiation of the host the consubstantiation, they say the wafer and the cup is not symbols, they are actually the blood and the body of Jesus Christ. **Those churches are crucifying Jesus all over again, and we cannot do that.** They are taking scripture where Jesus Christ will often say something with purposeful, not to mislead people, but He will say something so there is ambiguity so that you will figure it out later on. Like when He tells Judas, "*go and do quickly what thou must do.*" People around Him thought Judas is going to do some stuff. That is not what Jesus meant at all, if you take the teaching of the Lord's Supper incorrectly, you do not understand the spiritual power behind the words, you can shipwreck your faith.

You can go off on a tangent you not suppose to go off on, His cross work is over, please do not offer Him again. The work He has to do is the work the Father who has delegated Him to do. By the way, that proves He is God, He is not a ghost, not a good man, not a good teacher. He is not a high angel, all the **Mormons who teach that Jesus Christ is the half brother of Lucifer**; He is the Son of the Father and created being. The Mormons who teach that, by the way is becoming folded into the one world church. **Mitt Romney**, who is running for President says, "*I'm a Christian like you guys. I want to be treated like a born again Christian.*" I beg to differ; their teaching on the deity of the Lord Jesus Christ is very different. If you study the gospel message, you have to agree with who Jesus is; are you are not going to be saved.

III. ALL JUDGMENT DELEGATED TO JESUS CHRIST

Jesus Christ has all judgment delegated to Him. Only when we take, everything in our eternal soul is going to be judged. For some of these things, some of these people their judgment power has been a long time coming. Some of them are reserved in chains, even to this day, because God is merciful, loving, and kind to us. Everyone will be judged. You say, *“Not me, I’m going to escape,”* I do not think so. The Judgment of Jesus Christ undertakes will be just, perfect and awesome to behold. It will astound you. Whether you are the object of it or a spectator, you will say hallelujah, glory to God. Even if you are an object of that judgment, you will fall on your knees and you will say, *“Lord, He is God, Jesus Christ reigns forever.”* Even if you are the object of that judgment, you will not dispute it, even if you are led away shaking your fist saying, *“I was railroaded.”* It is going to be amazing judgment, more than we consider right now. Jesus Christ is going to be a wonderful and conferrable judge. His awesome judgments will bring glory to God the Father for intrusting this awesome work in His Son the Lord Jesus Christ.

IV. REWARDS

When we look, then at another component of judgment that is to come, that is the idea of **rewards**. By the way if you are going to judge all things, you have to judge the good and the bad. The bible is full of all these pieces of advice in the New Testament for believers. “Why don’t you do this, you got to think about this, why do you hold on to this, all these pieces of advice, the concepts that things would be good if you do good or bad or if you don’t. Now if God has given all this advice to us, do you think, He cares whether we obey or follow it, or listen to Him or not.

Might that be something He is going to entrust His Son to judge. We looked at that entire concept that born again Christians being judged for what they do. If we looked at the judgment of what the world deserves, it would be a pretty bleak message. If we looked at the judgment the **fallen angels** have earned and deserve, it would be a pretty bleak message. We look at what the redeemed already have. The redeemed are forgiven. That is the greatest blessing of all, to have your sin blotted out. We are loved also; we loved with a great love.

A blog I read is about a pastor dying of cancer. He is a pastor of a Baptist Church. The wife said his lungs were shutting down and they were putting him into hospice. . The pastor now is too weak to write. He knows where he is going. Even dying, a Christian knows he is loved. Death is like a shadow passing over us. Jesus said you are not going to die if you believe in Me; you are adopted, adopted into heavenly family, washed sanctified clean. According to God, He sees us in heaven; He does not see us here. We are married to Christ, washed, sealed with the Holy Spirit washed in the blood forever. Our names are written down in the lamb’s book of life, so what else as a born again believer, do we have? You can have all that and more.

I Corinthians 3:8 NASB

Now he who plants and he who waters are one; but each will receive his own reward according to his own labor.

Every man will receive the reward for the labor he has earned. You have a reward for the labor you are doing right now.

Sixteen things God rewards:

1. Keeping God's Word
2. Sowing righteousness
3. Fearing the commandments
4. Working together
5. Suffering persecution for Christ
6. Giving in alms secretly
7. Praying in secret
8. Fasting in secret
9. Receiving a prophet
10. Receiving a righteous man
11. Giving a cup of cold water
13. Bearing reproach for Christ
14. Loving your enemies
15. Building abiding works, preaching the Gospel
16. Doing everything cardinally

Doing these entire things, you will have a chance to earn a reward. Those behaviors are all rooted by the way we have a close walk with the Holy Spirit. You say, "*I don't need the Holy Spirit*" you will not have any reward; you will not be able to do any of that. What we are finding is prayer is enmity link to that. He that is spiritual, lives and breaths prayer! **The question left unanswered is rewarded with what?** What is the reward? You already have eternal life. You are adopted in the blood. You are seated in heavenly places in Jesus Christ. What more could you ask? **There is a certain mental illness among Christians today.** Look at the doctrine of salvation, they say, "I got all that, nothing else matters". That is not how you are suppose the think. "What else could I get"? I am going to prove to you that you are not supposing think that way. There are rewards and the one who earns their reward gains something.

Zechariah chapter 6:1

And I turned, and lifted up mine eyes, and looked, and, behold, there came four chariots out from between two mountains; and the mountains [were] mountains of brass.

I am going to ignore the prophetic component of one thing and toward the end of it.

Verse 2 .

In the first chariot [were] red horses; and in the second chariot black horses;

Verse 3.

And in the third chariot white horses; and in the fourth chariot grisled and bay horses.

Verse 4.

Then I answered and said unto the angel that talked with me, What [are] these, my lord?

Verse 5.

And the angel answered and said unto me, These [are] the four spirits of the heavens, which go forth from standing before the Lord of all the earth.

Verse 6.

The black horses which [are] therein go forth into the north country; and the white go forth after them; and the grisled go forth toward the south country.

Verse 7

And the bay went forth, and sought to go that they might walk to and fro through the earth: and he said, Get you hence, walk to and fro through the earth. So they walked to and fro through the earth.

Verse 8.

Then cried he upon me, and spake unto me, saying, Behold, these that go toward the north country have quieted my spirit in the north country.

There's a picture here, of God's throne, you may have read about that in Revelations in Isaiah prophecies, there is these wonderful trouble beast that are around the throne of God saying, "holy, holy, holy is the Lord God Almighty who was and is to come". He is surrounded by things to protect His holiness, because if something unholy gets in God's presence, it would not be pleasant what happens to the unholy thing. There are these incredible beasts, angelic beasts that God has created and they are around the throne and they are seen doing some things, other creatures like them going throughout the whole world.

Verse 9

And the word of the LORD came unto me, saying,

Verse 10

Take of [them of] the captivity, [even] of Heldai, of Tobijah, and of Jedaiah, which are come from Babylon, and come thou the same day, and go into the house of Josiah the son of Zephaniah;

Verse 11.

Then take silver and gold, and make crowns, and set [them] upon the head of Joshua the son of Josedech, the high priest;

Verse 12.

And speak unto him, saying, Thus speaketh the LORD of hosts, saying, Behold the man whose name [is] The BRANCH; and he shall grow up out of his place, and he shall build

the temple of the LORD:

This is the Messiah coming back, I not talking about the prophecy here.

Verse 13.

Even he shall build the temple of the LORD; and he shall bear the glory, and shall sit and rule upon his throne; and he shall be a priest upon his throne: and the counsel of peace shall be between them both.

Verse 14.

And the **crowns** shall be to Helem, and to Tobijah, and to Jedaiah, and to Hen the son of Zephaniah, for a memorial in the temple of the LORD.

Verse 15.

And they [that are] far off shall come and build in the temple of the LORD, and ye shall know that the LORD of hosts hath sent me unto you. And [this] shall come to pass, if ye will diligently obey the voice of the LORD your God

V. CROWNS

There are crowns seen in these verses. Two of these verses have crowns. Here is the Lord Jesus Christ, He has come back, and He is sitting right now, where there is a mosque in Jerusalem on Temple Mount. The Temple of the Lord is rebuilt. He is ruling where entire people all come to Him all over the world. Jesus Christ is King of Kings, Lord of Lords. No doubt about it, all glory is His. And yet, I note in his presence are people with crowns on. Isn't that amazing! **You say what is a crown. We do not wear hats today.**

I like to read history, like the old books, I have this book on the railroads in Toledo. I was laughing about that book, how it had a railway running up and down with a train. Which by the way when gas is four dollars a gallon, the electric train is a good idea. Great grandma and great grandpa had some good ideas. They would get on that train for three cents and would ride anywhere you wanted to go. By the way, Golden Rule Jones, the mayor of Toledo, shut down the train. They wanted to raise the price to five cents.

The mayor of Toledo said if they raised the price, they would loose their franchise. Socialist shut that whole thing down. When you look at that picture, everyone had hats on at that time. I am going somewhere where with this, everyone wore hats, I do not know what the reason was, but they all had hats. Did they have a hat store somewhere, or maybe it was colder back then, with global warming, I do not know. Therefore, you put a hat on for a reason, you have a crown. A crown is a hat, a special type of hat. What is the use for a crown? It does not keep the rain off, does it? If it is made out of gold, it does not keep your head warm. It signifies something; it has a message, doesn't it? It say's something, does God use messengers by the way? This entire chapter of Zechariah is a prophet that interacts with an angel, a messenger of God, who sends messages all the time.

Therefore, **a crown is a message for the future millennium reign of the kingdom of Jesus Christ.** What does a crown look like, who would use it? What golden, wonderfully fine made crown, by the way that is the only kind of crown God is going to let around him, you are not going to wear a dunce hat, a bozo hat, not going to happen. These are going to be beautiful crowns, valuable crowns, worn here. Who wears a crown? The joker, the naïve, the fool, no, kings and princes wear crowns. So the Savior is here sitting on His throne in His kingdom. You say, I do not see His kingdom. You have to see it with the eyes of faith a far off, but it is coming. Jesus Christ prayed, “Thy kingdom come thy will be done”. What is God’s kingdom going to be like? When God’s will is done on earth, it is done in heaven.

The state of Ohio just past a bill, our governor would not sign it, what a coward, he is a pastor, and he would not sign it. He won’t sign his name to a bill that says all of these adult cabarets, all the lascivious stores, abominable places, have to shut down at a certain hour, all these inconvenient things, he won’t sign his name to it. When God’s will is done on earth as it is in heaven, all those clubs will be permanently shut down. They won’t be able to operate up until midnight. I was amazed, I was driving, and a moron on the radio was saying how un-American it is to put rules on these clubs.

I thought you idiot, how would you like to live next to one of these? It’s not about freedom; it’s what it does to your house. Do you want those drunks passed out in your yard? Do you want to hear them crying? Do you want your mother living next to one of those? What a moron, it’s all about crime, zoning, and property value. It’s about freedom and not being unmolested in your house. He doesn’t understand that. However, there is coming a day, when all those things are going to be shut down.

The Kingdom is coming. The Prince of Peace is going to rule, He is going to have a rod of, not a little palm branch. He is not sissy Jesus. His enemies are going to be made His footstool. When He comes back visibly to set up His Kingdom, He is going to do something to His enemies; He is going to kill them all. The Prince of Peace ruling; how can He be the Prince of Peace, when He kills all His enemies? I thought you were a born again Christian and a peacemaker? I am, there is a time when all God’s patience’s ends. When we have done every thing, we can wrong in this age of grace, and God says I am done with this, this dispensation age of grace has not done any good, there is one more age of grace, and if you read the book, that is the kingdom age and that is going to fail too.

The King of Kings, the Prince of Peace, He is coming to establish His kingdom. He is going to have a crown on. It appears here in Zechariah, the King of Kings is going to allow other kings to reign with him. The Royal Palace of King Jesus in Jerusalem is going to have a stream of royal servants coming and going. Royal worshipers coming and going. You say, “*Are you going to have a jet plane to get on and go to Jerusalem so we can meet Jesus Christ face to face*”?

Yes, except it probably will not be a jet plane. I do not know what it will be, who knows what it will be, but it will be better than a jet plane. If you have flown on a jet plane

recently, they are not fun to be on. You will be able to go and meet Him. There will be a stream of visitors reporting to Him, worshipers coming, people coming to seek healing, seek relieve, equity, other things. Worshipers, and officials, some of them the bible says will be crowned.

Let us study these crowns, because they are going to exist in the future, but there is none today. You say why I am here, **why is that pastor you mentioned dying of cancer? He is in training, he is earning crowns. He is in training for service in the kingdom.** How sad it is going to be when some believers, when all the assignments are given out for kingdom service, God is going to have no use for you. You say, *"I'm still saved,"* yes you are, *"I'm still under the blood,"* yes you are, but God's not going to have any job or task for you to do. It is very easy to say that now. You will eat those words like dust. A thousand years from now you will say, ***"Oh, Oh, if I could go back, if I could go back and work, for the night is coming."***

There are five types of crowns detailed in the New Testament. Some people right in this room have earned some of these rewards. You say, *"I can't see them."* They are **invisible crowns.** It is an invisible kingdom is not yet. It is an **invisible bride** right now. These things are apprehended by faith. God is a rewarder of them that seek him and that believe. You cannot see them today, but with the eyes of faith. Our rewards will be given for all eternity. People will live forever with God the Father because they believe for what God the Son has said.

Jesus came upon a blind man one day; the bible says he was blind from birth. That is a real blind man. We do that to our selves today. We blind our selves with booze, all kinds of other things. This blind man is a picture for you and me. We are blind from birth, it is called sin. **There is no such thing called an age of accountability, I cannot find it.** But, there is such a thing a fallen simple race of rebels. A fallen race of rebels don't just make babies, they make sinner babies. Babies that want what they want. Here, is a blind man.

John 9:1

And as [Jesus] passed by, he saw a man which was blind from [his] birth

Verse 2.

And his disciples asked him, saying, Master, who did sin, this man, or his parents, that he was born blind?

Verse 3.

Jesus answered, Neither hath this man sinned, nor his parents: but that the works of God should be made manifest in him.

By the way you are seeing less and less people of downs syndrome today, there is a strange thought that says, someone is retarded, someone has downs syndrome, there is a little baby with a problem, their parents are in sin. That is not scriptural at all, that is

wicked. We are seeing fewer and fewer downs babies today. You know why, we are aborting them all in the womb before they are born. God is going to have justice for that is a sin.

verse 4

I must work the works of him that sent me, while it is day: the night cometh, when no man can work.

Verse 5.

As long as I am in the world, I am the light of the world.

Verse 6.

When he had thus spoken, he spat on the ground, and made clay of the spittle, and he anointed the eyes of the blind man with the clay,

Verse 7.

And said unto him, Go, wash in the pool of Siloam, (which is by interpretation, Sent.) He went his way therefore, and washed, and came seeing.

The almost entire religious community was outraged for that act of healing. *“How dare Jesus heal this man and work on the Sabbath.”* They said, *“God gave us the Sabbath to not work.”* Later you turn to verse 35 where Jesus is going to meet up with the formally blind man, who was cast out by the loving and kind religious experts, tortured by them, basically verbally.

Verse 35.

Jesus heard that they had cast him out; and when he had found him, he said unto him, Dost thou believe on the Son of God?

Verse 36.

He answered and said, Who is he, Lord, that I might believe on him?

Verse 37.

And Jesus said unto him, Thou hast both seen him, and it is he that talketh with thee.

Verse 38.

And he said, Lord, I believe. And he worshipped him.

Verse 39.

And Jesus said, For judgment I am come into this world, that they which see not might see; and that they which see might be made blind.

Verse 40.

And [some] of the Pharisees which were with him heard these words, and said unto him, Are we blind also?

Verse 41.

Jesus said unto them, If ye were blind, ye should have no sin: but now ye say, We see; therefore your sin remaineth.

If you read John chapter 10 verse 30. I and [my] Father are one. If you do not know Jesus Christ today as your personal savior, you will not know Him in eternity. He and His Father are one; you will not be allowed to know the Father. Jesus Christ said, "I and my Father are one." If you do not know Him as Savior today, you will not know His Father in eternity. You will not live with the Father, you will not be able to see the Father, and you will not be able to talk with the Father. The relationship with Jesus Christ today is one hundred per cent positively correlated with the relationship in the future with God the Father.

They will line up perfectly. I and My Father are one. There is nothing more important in your life than the relationship with Jesus Christ. Do you know Him, has He healed your blindness, have you believed on Him, do you call Him Lord. Why is this important? Well ironically, what we are studying has to do with the crown. Look at Matthew 27:27, Jesus Christ has already worn a crown for you. We will have an opportunity to wear better crowns in the future. He wore a crown I no longer have to wear.

Matthew 27:27

Then the soldiers of the governor took Jesus into the common hall, and gathered unto him the whole band [of soldiers].

Verse 28.

And they stripped him, and put on him a scarlet robe.

Verse 29.

And when they had platted a crown of thorns, they put [it] upon his head, and a reed in his right hand: and they bowed the knee before him, and mocked him, saying, Hail, King of the Jews!

Verse 30.

And they spit upon him, and took the reed, and smote him on the head.

Verse 31.

And after that they had mocked him, they took the robe off from him, and put his own raiment on him, and led him away to crucify [him].

VI. FIVE TYPES OF CROWNS

You can win and earn five types of crowns today, only because He has already worn the crown of thorns for you and me. Only because He has died for you and me. If you are born again, by believing that Jesus Christ has paid the horrible price for sins, you have a possibility of wearing and winning five types of crowns. This is a type of

behavior, which will give you a crown.

1. THE RUNNERS CROWN-THE INCORRUPTIBLE CROWN

First Corinthians, Paul was talking to people who knew about the Olympic Games. The Olympics games were equivalent to football. The Olympic Games today are about money. It is all about sponsorship, blood doping, human growth hormones. You say the Olympics are the amateur athletes of the world today. You are a fool, they are all getting paid. We build them training complexes, they get salaries, and scholarships, and they get hundreds of thousands of dollars to train for the Olympics. Those are amateurs.

In the past communist governments forced, their own citizens to undergo chemical mutilations to become faster and better and some of them changed who they were. The Germans changed men into women and women into men, uncommon stuff. Now it is simply the power of pure money to help the athletes to win and prevail. The fully amateur games are now professional games. They are a sink hole of corruption. You say “say how do you know they are corrupt?” The last ones we had in America were jailed or lost their jobs, or were fined, because they all were corrupt. The Olympics in Ba Jing, I am going to make a prediction, is going to be worse than the Olympics since Adolph Hitler in 1936 in Berlin. This is going to be a disgusting Olympics.

The communist regime of China is busy is right now slaughtering its people. You do not hear this in the media. The American press does not have anything; they do not own anything, without the authority of the China Government... The china government swoops in, makes forced abortions, kills people, shoots people and covers it up. That is all through out rural China going on. There is a wealthy class in China right now. They are eating fancy food and living in fancy apartments, built on us buying trinkets sold by Wal Mart.

You buy a socket set made in China for \$4.99, Wal Mart buys it for \$2.00, and some Chinese person got a nickel for it. In addition, you think you got a good deal. You use it once, its pot medal and it breaks. You think you got a good deal. Well, I go to Sears, I tell my wife, there is something seriously wrong with me? I am at Sears and I am driving a truck, and there is something that just doesn’t work. I buy Craftsmen tools, because it says; made in America. You can actually use them a couple of times. They last; I got sockets that I have had for years. You can go save money, and go buy at Wal Mart. The Chinese people are slaves ,their government is making them slaves. They are torching the people, and make them slaves.

It is going to be a wonderful Olympics. An Olympic based on slavery. That being said, there is nothing changed since 2000 years of Olympic competition. In Corinthians, it tells us, you have to run the race all the way to the end to win the price. The races have changed now for the most part. We still have the marathon. The word marathon came from a battle.

1 Corinthians 9:24

Know ye not that they which run in a race run all, but one receiveth the prize? So run, that ye may obtain.

This is not guaranteed, you will not win the price. You have to run it a certain way.

Verse 25

And every man that striveth for the mastery is temperate in all things. Now they [do it] to obtain a corruptible crown; but we an incorruptible.

A good man or woman, who is going to run the race, has to master some things. What are they going to master if you are going to run the race? You have to do a lot of things. At the night of the race, do you want to be at the bar carousing? That would give me an edge for the race tomorrow. You have striven for the master, you failed. Now they [do it] to obtain a corruptible crown; but we an incorruptible.

I am talking about 5 crowns you earn as a Christian. In addition, **Jesus Christ is our incorruptible crowns.** Paul's advice says:

Verse :26

I therefore so run, not as uncertainly; so fight I, not as one that beateth the air: I am not doing stupid things.

Verse 27

But I keep under my body, and bring [it] into subjection: lest that by any means, when I have preached to others, I myself should be a castaway.

Paul is speaking about the race you are running right now. Paul has already run the race. **Every single, born again believer runs this race. If you start this race the moment you are saved, you say, "It feels like I'm in a battle, not a race."** That is true, Paul says:

1 Timothy 1:18

This charge I commit unto thee, son Timothy, according to the prophecies which went before on thee, that thou by them mightest war a good warfare;

You say this is not a normal race. There are people opposing me while I am running. That is true.

2 Corinthians 10:3

For though we walk in the flesh, we do not war after the flesh:

Verse 4

(For the weapons of our warfare [are] not carnal, but mighty through God to the pulling down of strong holds;)

Paul told Timothy:

1 Timothy 6:12

Fight the good fight of faith, lay hold on eternal life, whereunto thou art also called, and hast professed a good profession before many witnesses. to fight the good fight of faith, lay hold to the good fight of eternity.

2 Timothy 4:7

I have fought a good fight, I have finished [my] course, I have kept the faith:

It starts the moment you and I are saved. It ends when you die. You pass off this mortal and you are in the bosom of the Lord. It ends then. Our lives are the course of the world. The venue of this race is the world. This is a very dangerous race. **There are spiritual opponents and enemies. Praise God you are not running this race alone, because Jesus Christ is with you.** He said He would send the comforter; He said He would never leave you or forsake you. He said He would show us and tell us all things. He said he would never leave us.

He said the Holy Spirit is going to pace us and aid us. We are running with the gold of finishing, but there are some people who are not going to finish well. They are just as saved as you or I. We have a name for them, "quieter." Some people quiet. **Some people break the rules.** You say, "I thought he was a Christian." "He did that, I thought you could not do that to be a Christian." He broke the rules. **Some people will cheat, some stop caring. Some will train poorly; the running of the course will distract some.** You will be running along by a Christian who stops and you say, "come and run with me." You ask, "What are you doing?" He says, "I'm not racing anymore." You say, "We use to race together." There are mirrored of reasons why Christians can run this race poorly. There are millions of reasons to quiet, but **Jesus wants me to be a winner. He wants me to go all the way to the end, since He gave His live for me and wore the crown of thorns for me. Are you running well Christian? Are you doing what it takes to win? Are you progressing?**

Let us look at this verse again.

Verse 25

And every man that striveth for the mastery is temperate in all things. Now they [do it] to obtain a corruptible crown; but we an incorruptible.

It does not fade, it is permanent. Only some believers are going to win it. The bible says, "Run that you may obtain it." You might win it. There is a little variable there. There is an option there. You may obtain or may not obtain it. It depends on how you run the race. **You do not get a crown at the Olympics for showing up. How many crowns in the Olympics do they give out? They give out three, gold, silver, and bronze.** I do not want the crown for showing up. That is a paper crown. That is not going to do any good. You have to run and win and compete according to the rules.

That is the only way the job is going to be accomplished to get the crown. **That rule has not changed.** You may obtain or you may not. Depends on how you run the race. Does it matter? Only in eternity does it matter. Christians, who run this race and win it, will

have a crown for all eternity and it is going to matter. It is going to count, more than gold or medal of the Olympics of today. **This is a spiritual race. It is also a physical race and a mental race. It is a race for character, prayer, faith and all that seem to matter.** When we look

1 Corinthians 9:27

But I keep under my body, and bring [it] into subjection: lest that by any means, when I have preached to others, I myself should be a castaway.

You cannot win it unless you obey the rules. You will not win it unless you keep your body into subjection. Paul said I keep my body into subjection. There are certain rules you have to do. Christians you have to do certain things with your body, or you are going to be a cast away. Your body, being made from simple parents, still has a simple corrupt nature. You say, "I am saved, I won't ever sin again." You are a liar, you just sinned, your body has set to it, and it wants to do simple things. If you take your body to places, and have a habit of that, you are going to be more likely to sin in certain ways. I do not like these stripe clubs, and some in this church went and picketed a certain club. We were thanked for it. We got threaten for it, lawsuits. However, you know what they are gone and we are here.

If I went to strip clubs all the time as a born a gain Christians, and a pastor went there, and say I would not doing anything wrong, I am going there to read my Bible. You would laugh. That is ludicrous. If you go to read your Bible at a strip club, you are just asking to be disqualified. You do not take the race seriously. Paul said all things are lawful unto me, but all things are not expedient. All things are lawful for me, but I will not be brought down under the power of any. Peter said, *"dearly beloved I beseech you as strangers and pilgrims, abstain from fleshly lust, which war against the soul."* **Are your eyes on the prize?** If your eyes are on the prize, or your own body, you are not running the race right. We have many Christians today that say, "Well that ok, I can't see that, I can only see now." Those people do not want to win. They do not desire to win. My advice, "gird up the loins of your mind, run the race to win the incorruptible crown.

There are five crowns. You get a runners crown first. By the way, how many Christians can run the Runners Crown? All of them, right. How many are in the race. All of them are in the race, the Soul Winners Crown.

2. THE SOUL WINNERS CROWN. THE CROWN OF REJOICING

1 Thessalonians 2:17

But we, brethren, being taken from you for a short time in presence, not in heart, endeavoured the more abundantly to see your face with great desire

Verse 18

Wherefore we would have come unto you, even I Paul, once and again; but Satan hindered us.

Verse 19 For what [is] our hope, or joy, or crown of rejoicing? [Are] not even ye in the presence of our Lord Jesus Christ at his coming?

1 Thessalonians 2:20

For ye are our glory and joy

Paul is revering here, to lost sinners, that God had used him to witness to and that faithful witness combined with the Holy Spirit resulted in faith. Thessalonica pagans and unbelieving Jews became born again Christians. I want to encourage you to look at the context of this verse. At the coming of our Lord Jesus Christ, Paul teaches, we are going to know each other. A soul saved is precious in God's sight and holy angels are looking at the awesome transaction of salvation, when a sinner becomes a saint. There is rejoicing in heaven when one sinner believes. Paul looks forward here. He is looking for the day for the return of King Jesus when all believers will be reunited into the body.

He says, in verse 19

"for what is our hope, or joy or crown of rejoicing? Are not even ye in the presence of our Lord Jesus Christ at his coming?"

When Jesus Christ comes again, believers you are going to know me and remember me, and I am going to know you. You say, "Our bodies are going to be changed." Yes, but you are still you. You are still going to remember your long lost friend, your long lost brothers and sisters. You're long lost family. You are going to know, even as you are known. He looks at these believers and says, *"You're going to be my crown of rejoicing."*

How do you earn it? Are you longing, praying, and working to see lost sinners saved? You cannot do it, but God can. How do you do it, **being a faithful witness?** If you have, you will, you will have a **crown of rejoicing**. Just one would be enough. I trust at least one believer could lead at least one person to the Lord in their walk in the race, somewhere in their Christian experience. If you have done it one time, you have a crown waiting for you. That person, God used you in their life. Imagine if you were wearing that crown, do you think it might shine a little brighter when you are with that one person, or those twenty people you led to the Lord? Do you think it might shine a little brighter? It will cause both the wearer and the one saved to rejoice. That will be a wonderful crown.

3. THE LOVERS CROWN—THE CROWN OF LIFE

You, get the Runners Crown, the Soul Winner Crown (Witness Crown) and now the Lovers Crown.

James 1:12

Blessed [is] the man that endureth temptation: for when he is tried, he shall receive the crown of life, which the Lord hath promised to them that love him.

For when he is tried, it does not say if he is tried. When he is tried, he must run the race, he shall receive the crown of life. What kind of crown? The Lord promised a Crown of Life to them that love him. There is a Crown of Life, a Lovers Crown. I have a dear brother, who teaches, that the Book of James is not for today. They teach that the Book of James is for the Kingdom. That is heresy All scripture is given. James 1:12 promises a wonderful crown. You run the race a certain way. You endure the temptation that is to come. If you are running the race, you will be tempted. Apparently, my brother is not interest in wearing this crown.

That is sad, because the bible says, *“Blessed is the man that endures temptation.”* We have the incredibly stupid idea today, in the American; evangelical theological system of today, that the man embraces temptation is going to be rewarded. That is what we believe today. **That is the new translation.** “Blesses the man that embraces temptation?” That is what we act like, “let’s bring the world into church, and let’s bring the sewer of pornography in our house.” There is sewage all over your house. Oh, yes, we really believe that! Embracing is not quiet the same as enduring. There is a little different thought. Enduring has a thought of persevering without comprising.

When you bring the worlds entertainment devices in the temple of God, the sewage in the church of God, you are embracing it, not enduring it. When you attempt to foolishly worship God, the Holy God with such things, you are not enduring, you are embracing corruption. You are not persevering, you are not staying away from it, you are not bearing, and you are compromising.

We are surrounded by a great cloud of witness, telling us that we are able to compromise the things of God. That is what they are telling us. You say, **“They got numbers on their side.”** Well the devil always had numbers on his side.

They tell us today, you must mix the profane with the holy, we must dishonor the word of God in our services. We must mock the Lamb of God, while singing to the Lamb of God. That is what these people are saying. We must read the word of God, while following the God of the world and we must love the world and at the same time love the Lord. Every large church in Ohio must subscribe to this philosophy. They have to, to bring the crowds in. If you want two thousand people, you have to subscribe to this philosophy. **My question is, “Do you love the Lord if you disobey Him” Do you love the Lord if you are not going to follow him?**

James 1:12

Blessed [is] the man that endureth temptation: for while he is tried, he shall receive the crown of life, which the Lord hath promised to them that love him.

How do you show you love Him, with your lips or with your life? It works better with both, but if you have to be pick one, which one would you pick? If you say you love Him, you show it by what you do and what you say. It is not that hard to understand. The concepts in this verse tell us, it is with our life. The greatest trials and temptations you will ever have, they are test. You say this is happening, that is happening, you have cancer; they are test. Do not get mad at God, they are test. You are

being tested, so that you can show that you love the Lord Jesus Christ. What an honor, what a privilege. What a wonderful blessing, what a gracious, wonderful giving and merciful God. **Trials and temptations are opportunities to winning a crown.** Here is the Lovers Crown; do you want to win that? I hope we have that. I hope I see you in heaven.

I hope every member of my church has the Lovers Crown on. If you do not, it means you did not endure temptation; you did not love Him. **How many believers will be without this crown in glory? I fear many. I fear many will be without this crown. Many will have made a bad bargain. Many will be chosen and believe and be saved, and throw away the opportunity to win this crown.** Oh, but I love men more than my savior, “I love this, I love that.” This is sad. **If you have this crown, you will have a patch that says, “Overcome.”**

That will be wonderful to have. “**Victor**” ran all the way. How would you like to have “**Faithful**” on your uniform? Is that a good name to have on there? This crown is for those who endure and win the crown.

4. THE SHEPHERDS CROWN—THE CROWN OF GLORY

This is, concerning the Christians, it is going to be very rare.

1Peter 5:1

The elders which are among you I exhort, who am also an elder, and a witness of the sufferings of Christ, and also a partaker of the glory that shall be revealed:

What is an elder? It is a pastor, a bishop.

Verse:2

Feed the flock of God which is among you, taking the oversight [thereof], not by constraint, but willingly; not for filthy lucre, but of a ready mind

Entertain them, feed their lust. Oh, it doesn't say that. That is the modern American theology.

Verse :3

Neither as being lords over [God's] heritage, but being ensamples to the flock.

Verse 4

And when the chief Shepherd shall appear, ye shall receive a crown of glory that fadeth not away.

Not everybody can win this crown. That is just how it is. That is God's economy. **It is a crown with eternal qualities. A crown does not fade.** It rewards work with fruit that does not fade away. That makes sense. The shepherd here is a wonderful metaphor for

the pastor. He is a under shepherd. The Lord Jesus Christ is the Good Shepherd, the Chief Shepherd. By the way, if you are an under shepherd, whose orders should you be following? You would be following the Lord Jesus Christ orders. This crown does not fade. You can follow Jesus Christ.

He gave His own life for the sheep. The position of pastor, by the way, **how do I earn the position of the pastor? You cannot. How do you apply for it? You cannot. You have to be called!** The bible says you have to be called. God knows whom He calls, and He equips those He calls. God calls men to be a pastor. **He does not call women to be a pastor. Show me a woman pastor and I will show you a woman unequipped who is not going to win this crown.** Some people say, *"You have to do full time Christian service."* I do not do full time Christian service.

I know many people who do full time Christian service, who are not equipped to be a pastor. I know pastors who do not do full time Christian service. However, they are faithful in what God has called them to do.

Shepherds Crown, we are talking about! **You cannot earn the position of pastor or apply for it.** You do not go to seminary to be a pastor. You are called to it. You can do other things. God can prepare you, He has His own plan for you, for every under shepherd He calls. **Your life becomes an intricate part of what we are teaching and your family becomes an intricate part of the messenger. Your marriage becomes an intricate part of the testimony qualification. Your relationships from others are open to inspection. They affect the message and your position. The bible says you are subject to greater condemnation.** Do not get jealous of the pastor of the crown he gets to have.

The souls of your hearers are now in your hands if you are a under shepherd. The pastor that falls does not fall alone. The pastor that comes to false doctrine does not fall alone. **The pastor that brings shame to Christ, does not harm just himself, but a God that also rewards.** Peter said, *"And when the chief Shepherd shall appear, ye shall receive a crown of glory that fadeth not away."*

5. THE WATCHERS CROWN—THE CROWN OF RIGHTEOUSNESS

It is believed Second Timothy was Paul's last letter before he died. At the end of this letter, you will find the following verses:

2 Timothy 4:1

I charge [thee] therefore before God, and the Lord Jesus Christ, who shall judge the quick and the dead at his appearing and his kingdom;

Verse 2

Preach the word; be instant in season, out of season; reprove, rebuke, exhort with all longsuffering and doctrine.

Verse 3

For the time will come when they will not endure sound doctrine; but after their own lusts shall they heap to themselves teachers, having itching ears;

By the way, the time has come in 2007, when they will not endure sound doctrine.

Verse :4

And they shall turn away [their] ears from the truth, and shall be turned unto fables.

Verse 5

But watch thou in all things, endure afflictions, do the work of an evangelist, make full proof of thy ministry.

Verse 6

For I am now ready to be offered, and the time of my departure is at hand.

Verse 7

I have fought a good fight, I have finished [my] course, I have kept the faith:

Verse 8

Henceforth there is laid up for me a crown of righteousness, which the Lord, the righteous judge, shall give me at that day: and not to me only, but unto all them also that love his appearing.

The Watchers Crown. **Who can win this crown? All that loves His appearing. What a challenge for the believer in these last days.** A crown for any and all who love His appearing. This verse destroys not only non-dispensationalist, the non-millenniums, it looks forward the day, the Lord Jesus is going to come back. We know that day will be hidden in secret for His church, and seven years later, it will be open, obvious, and divisive as he returns as the King to establish His Kingdom on earth for one thousand year reign.

If you are wearing the Runners Crown, have won the Soul Winners Crown, and have loved and earned the Lovers Crown, you will very likely have the Watchers Crown. Reserved for those who are faithfully watching and waiting for the imminent return of the Lord Jesus Christ. Why wait for this? Why long for this? Why watch for this? Paul said, "as it is written, eye hath not seen, nor ear heard, neither enter in the heart of man the things which God hath prepared for him that love Him.

However, beloved, we are going to be so much better off when He comes. It is going to be a blessed day. I hope you are watching and waiting for His appearing. Paul said, in

II Corinthians 5:2

For in this we groan, earnestly desiring to be clothed upon with our house which is from heaven:

He said this in Titus 2 :13

Looking for that blessed hope, and the glorious appearing of the great God and our Saviour Jesus Christ;

I have only seen Him in His Word today. That is the only way I have seen Him. That is the only way you have seen Him. I have only seen Him with the eyes of faith, not with my real eyes. I greatly desire, more than anything else, to see my Lord. I want to be with Him. I want Him to return, or I want to pass and be with Him in glory, when He calls me. I want to see Him with my eyes. Oh, I want to see Him. I want to fall at His feet and weep with tears of joy. He saved me from my sins. I want to see Him and thank Him for that! I want to touch Him, I want to touch His feet, that would be enough, the hem of His garment, and I just want to thank Him. I want to say thank You for saving me. I have not done that yet.

We sing a song about it. It goes like this, “As I journey through the land singing as I go, pointing souls to Calvary through the crimson flow. Many arrows pierced my soul from without within, but my Lord leads me on, through Him I must win.” The frame is, “Oh I want to see Him to look upon His face. There to sing forever of His saving grace. On the streets of glory, let me lift my voice, care all past, home at last, ever to rejoice. When in service for my Lord, Dark may be the night, but I’ll cling more close to Him and He will give me light. Satan snares may vex my soul, turn my thoughts aside, but my Lord goes ahead, leads what ever besides. When in valley low I look, toward the mountain height, and behold my Savior there, leading in the fight.

With a tender hand out stretched toward the valley low, guiding me, I can see, as I onward go. When before me, billows rise, from the mighty deep, then my Lord directs my bark, He doeth safely keep, and He leads me gently on through this world below. He a friend to me, and Oh, I love Him so.”

Christian are you watching? Are you witnessing? Are you enduring? Are you running the race of four wonderful crowns? If you are saved today and if you are a pastor, there is a fifth crown. The other four are much more important. Four wonderful crowns. Anyone can win; every believer ought to win if you run the race all the way to the end. Sinner, if you are not saved, you will get none of these crowns, because the crown of thorns was not for you.

If you have not accepted, you have not believed that Jesus Christ has paid for your sins. Oh, how sad it will be to go to a lack of fire forever, with your sins paid. However, the sin of unbelief will be charged to your account. Believe today! Believer watch today, work today! Run the race all the way, endure trials and temptations, and love His appearing.